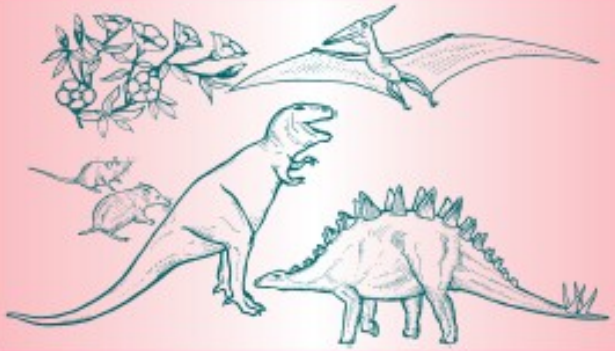
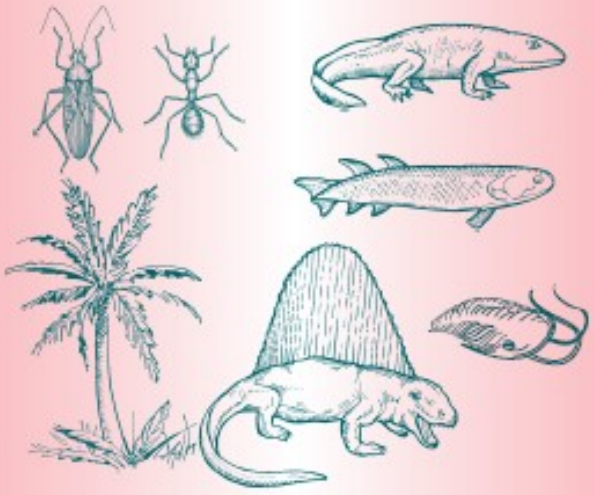
The Geological Time Scale

Era	Period	Millions of years ago (mya)	Life/comments	
Cenozoic (recent life)	Quaternary	0–2	Humans (*Homo sapiens*)	
	Tertiary	2–65	Mammals and birds become dominant after extinction of the dinosaurs	
Mesozoic (middle life)	Cretaceous	65–144	Final period for dinosaurs; small mammals, flowering plants; *Tyrannosaurus* lived around 65–68 mya	
	Jurassic	144–208	Plant-eating dinosaurs abundant, flying reptiles, first birds; *Apatosaurus* (formerly *Brontosaurus*) lived around 150–156 mya	
	Triassic	208–248	Dinosaurs, tiny mammals	
Palaeozoic (ancient life)	Permian	248–290	Modern insects; new mountains, deserts	
	Carboniferous	290–362	Reptiles evolve from amphibians	
	Devonian	362–408	Many types of fish, first land animals, amphibians, tree-sized land plants	
	Silurian	408–438	Early simple land plants, first insects	
	Ordovician	438–505	Fish, corals, molluscs	
	Cambrian	505–570	Worm-like creatures, first vertebrates—eel-like animals, animals with shells (e.g. trilobites)	
Proterozoic (earlier life)	Precambrian	570–2700	Single-celled animals, early sea plants, fungi	
	Archaeozoic (primitive life)	2700–3500	First signs of life—algae and bacteria	
	Azoic (without life)	3500–4600	No life; Earth still cooling after its creation	